

IN TOON (Clockwise from left) Comic strips *Bantul the Great*, *Robir Abirbhab* and *Anandamath*, and a comic in *Sandesh* magazine

From political, detective and crime thrillers... Bengali comics have straddled various genres over the years

dered idly whether a book on comics in Bengal would ever see the light of day. I immediately dismissed the thought, thinking that it would be too diverse and hard to classify," admits Pinaki De, comics researcher and practitioner and a member of the collective.

But what was only an amorphous thought is slowly becoming a possibility with this ongoing exhibition that has managed to scan and archive many books, periodicals, magazines and newspaper strips.

It has been about a century since one of the first comic strips was published in Bengal. 'Jemon Kormo Temni Phol', a picture-story by Shukhalata Rao that was printed in the *Poush* 1328 issue of the famous literary magazine *Sandesh*, is regarded as the first Bengali comic complete with speech bubbles. It was written and illustrated by writer-activist Rao who was also part of the illustrious Ray family—Satyajit Ray's aunt and Upendrakishore Ray Chowdhury's eldest daughter.

"This exhibition aims to uncover the vibrant legacy of storytelling, adventure and creativity that has shaped the comic culture in Bengal," says Richa Agarwal, chairperson, Kolkata Centre for Creativity. The artworks also mirror the sociopolitical climate of their times. For instance, the Swadeshi movement, Bengal's partition and the Noakhali riots are depicted in 'Sanyashi Ak Jatri', in the pre-independence mouthpiece of the Congress, *Sonar Bangla*.

From the early comics, political, detective and crime thrillers, advertising, pseudo-historical, biographical mythological and science fiction, Bengali comics have over the years straddled various genres and each is showcased.

The exhibition also briefly dwells on translated comics like *Aranyadeb* (Phantom) or translations of Tintin, Tarzan and Henry and how they impacted the milieu. While the translations became hugely popular and 'captured the imagination of an entire generation', they invite a question. Raised by Abhijit Gupta, professor in Jadavpur University's Department of English, in his illustrated talk on the inaugural day of the exhibition: "Was it at the cost of Bengali voices?" The question, one hopes, will lead to encouraging answers. ■

–Malini Banerjee

Comics in Bengal is on at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity till March 9



City-based gallery Experimenter, among the curatorial partners for TRI in 2024, brought together Prabhakar Pachpute's *Sea of Fists* and Kallol Datta's *Volume 3 Issue 2 | 2.0* for TRI's opening exhibitions.

Pachpute's characteristic charcoal-drawn bodies of farmers with their heads replaced by sickles, spades, pickaxes and fists has taken over TRI's ground floor. The first floor belongs to Datta's ambitious installation where the clothes maker has juxtaposed garments and textile objects donated by various people across Manipur, Japan and elsewhere with foliage and soil denoting histories and stories associated with the garments.

"Trained in women's design, Datta wanted to escape the literal boundaries of clothing in the fashion industry, and so he transitioned into the fine-art world," explains St John. "Initially, he used mannequins or similar forms to showcase his garments, but, recently, he began making garments without a body in mind. Everything you see here is recycled clothing and the foliage which was fresh when first installed but has now started to decay echoing life itself and the life cycles of our clothes."

Assistant curator Muskan Kaur Sukarchakia points at a bridal tunic belonging to a grandmother from Lahore, which carried sediment in its seams because the tradition was for the community's women to spread soil in the fabric so the bride could carry her home with her to her in-laws. Kaur recalls how this suggests "material memory"—the basis of historian Aanchal Malhotra's Partition-themed book *Remnants of a Separation*. ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

Sea of Fists and *Volume 3 Issue 2 | 2.0* will be on show at TRI (53/2/2, Hazra Road, Ballygunge, Kolkata 700019) till April 15